Hand Hygiene: Educational Reference Notes

Hand hygiene means cleaning hands to reduce the spread of germs. Hands should be cleaned before preparing or eating food, after using the toilet, after coughing or sneezing, after handling rubbish, and whenever they are visibly dirty. Washing with soap and clean running water is an effective method. Rub all hand surfaces, including backs of hands, between fingers, and around nails, then rinse and dry. When soap and water are not available and hands are not visibly dirty, an alcohol-based hand rub may be used according to its label. Hand hygiene is one part of infection prevention and works alongside safe food handling, respiratory etiquette, and appropriate cleaning. Children can be supported by making handwashing accessible and demonstrating the steps.